

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 12
Another Kind of Freedom ~ The Sacred Potential of a Moment
23 August 2026

COMMUNION

Laura away

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: CTP and Megan Mascena

Organ Prelude-Concert

Fantasia and Fugue in C minor, BWV 537 – Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750)

Let Us Break Bread Together – Chelsea Chen (b. 1983)

Méditation – Maurice Duruflé (1902-1986)

Sonata No. 2 in D major – Elisabetta de Gambarini (1731–1765)

Transformations: Fantasia on “Pange Lingua” – Jessica French (b. 1984)

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[Chad & Megan to center chancel]

Welcome

Rev. CTP

Words of Gathering

MM & CTP

MM: We live our lives with little regard
for the import of each moment.

They come to us
in regular and rapid succession,
and we live through each of them into the next.

A simple, ongoing process
into which our lives are set at birth
and through which we will proceed unto our deaths.

CTP: Yet in each moment resides incredible power –
new life,
healing,
opportunity,
and we, who stumble through them
look to one another as we gather,
that we may do together
the work of opening one another
to the mysteries of this life,

and our potential of living to the fullest.

Both: *Today, may our singing be filled with transformation,
may our words reflect the yearning of our hearts,
and may the Spirit of Life that builds within us as we gather,
hallow each and every passing moment
we know here together.*

[adapt/gv/lvf]

MM: In expectation of what shall be,
we ask all of this.
Amen and Amen!

CTP: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering** *Listen, Now We Tell a Mystery* BEECHER

Listen, now we tell a mystery, told by prophets long before;
We will all be changed forever; pain and death will be no more.
With the Spirit's healing power faith becomes reality;
We proclaim immortal glory far beyond what we can see.

Sound the transformation trumpet; sing a song of victory;
Heaven and earth join in the chorus, welcoming new liberty.
Ever changing, ever growing, we claim all we're meant to be,
Joining in the Spirit's work of setting all creation free.

Celebrate new life eternal, springing from Creative Love;
Resurrection brings rejoicing all around us and above.
With the liberating Spirit, we will soar on angel wings,
Ever onward, ever forward, as the world in triumph rings.

-Lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

[Chad center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness

CTP

Let us join prayer together:

O Great life-giving Spirit,
whose voice we hear in the winds,
and whose warm breath gives life to all the world –
hear us humans on planet earth.

*Help us to remember
we are a part of the universe,
as natural and necessary as the rocks,
trees, and birds,*

perhaps no more important, nor any less.

Let us walk in beauty, Spirit of Life,
let our spirits see the dynamic quality of life in all that exists
with no prejudice or malice toward any creation.
May we begin to remember who we are in the natural order of life
as we stand in our own shallow pools of time.

*May we come to know, O Spirit,
what time it is
in our lives and in all life.
Amen.* [adapt/fpeavey]

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

Good Trouble

Thomas Keesecker

Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

This day has challenged us to make good trouble to make this world a better place.

[Megan to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

MM

Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Chad center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

CTP

Life shines out at us from even the shadowed corners
beckoning us to be drawn into its truth.
With classic precision,
the options for peace are placed before us.

We hesitate, laugh at the possibilities,
shrug off the responsibilities
and go about our merry way,
happy to leave whatever
those shadows may have brought.

In this hour, we turn toward those corners,
we sink into their deep mysteries,
open ourselves to life's possibilities,
yearn after its truths
and notice, feel the weight of, and accept the responsibility
life has placed upon us.

We are called to see with eyes that can see,
hear with ears that can hear,
and live our lives as those filled with purpose.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Megan to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

from 1 Kings

MM

Hear now this reading from First Kings, chapter 19, from the Hebrew Bible...

Elijah got up and ate and drank; then he went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights to Horeb the mount of God. At that place he came to a cave and spent the night there.

Then the word of God came to him, saying, “What are you doing here, Elijah?” He answered, “I have been very zealous for the God of hosts, for the Israelites have forsaken your covenant, thrown down your altars, and killed your prophets with the sword. I alone am left, and they are seeking my life, to take it away.”

The Voice said, “Go out and stand on the mountain before God, for they are about to pass by.” Now there was a great wind, so strong that it was splitting mountains and breaking rocks in pieces before God, but God was not in the wind, and after the wind an earthquake, but God was not in the earthquake, and after the earthquake a fire, but God was not in the fire, and after the fire a sound of sheer silence.

When Elijah heard it, he wrapped his face in his mantle and went out and stood at the entrance of the cave. Then there came a voice to him that said, “What are you doing here, Elijah?”

This is the witness of the ancients...

Thanks be to God!

[Emma transition Chad to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

CTP

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Inside each of us there awaits a wonder – a full spirit of freedom.
The Spirit of Freedom waits to dance in the rooms of our hearts
that are closed and cluttered.

The Spirit waits to dance in the spaces where negative feelings
have built barricades and stock-piled weapons.

The Spirit waits to dance in the corners where we still do not
believe in our goodness.

Inside each of us there awaits a wonder – full spirit of freedom
and she will lift light feet and make glad songs within us
on the day we open the door of our ego
and let the naysayers stomp out. [Joyce Rupp]

And if we do...if we do – perhaps we might just change the world.

[2 minutes of silence, then Emma transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Let us pray together:

That truth has been inscribed into my heart
and into the heart of every human being,
there to be read and revered,

thanks be to you, O God.

That there are ways of seeing and sensitivities of knowing
hidden deep in the palace of the soul,
waiting to be discovered,
ready to be set free,
thanks be to you.

Open our senses to wisdom's inner promptings
that we may give voice to what we hear in our souls
and be changed for the healing of the world,
*that we may listen for truth in every living soul
and be changed for the well-being of the world.*
Amen and Amen.

-J. Phillip Newell, Prayer for Wisdom

[Emma transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem

I Flow, I Am
Laude

Mari Esabel Valverde
text: Rainer Maria Rilke

And if the world has ceased to hear you, say to the silent earth: I flow. To the rushing water speak: I am.

[Emma transition Michael to pulpit]

Sermon

The Sacred Potential of a Moment

ML

[Emma transition as Michael & Chad go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

CTP & ML

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

ML: Holiest Mystery,
Community of Love,
Creator, Christ, Spirit,
Three in One,
you in Christ,
Christ in us,
and everywhere, Spirit,
connecting, caressing, cajoling us into the
image of wholeness tattooed on the heart and
the soul of every living thing.

We are not alone,
never isolated except in the imagination of
our wounded hearts.

CTP: The Christ abides in us,

and we in they,
and the joy of this is why we sing,
and why we pray,
and why we take our place
in this joyous communion, saying:

*Thank you for this banquet of love,
this feast of joy,
this miracle of common purpose
through the Christ who taught us,
with goodness and grace.*

ML [as Chad breaks bread]

At this gathering in this sacred place
we take bread as Jesus took bread,
and we remember as Jesus remembered,
the constant presence
of the Spirit of Life and Love.

We break and share this bread
as Jesus broke and shared it.

We share this bread as our pledge of openness
to the Spirit in our midst,
and in acknowledgement
of our eternal connectedness with the Spirit of Life.

CTP [as Michael pours cup]

We take this fruit of the vine and pour it as Jesus poured it.

We drink as Jesus invited the friends to drink,
mindful of the relationship of love and trust
between ourselves and the Spirit of Life,
believing as Jesus believed,
that beyond pain and shadows and death,
life in the Spirit continues
in ways beyond our imagining.

ML: You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we

remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Megan to lectern, Brandon center]

Invitation to Generosity

MM

Throughout this summer,
we have acknowledged that life - our life and all lives -
are a gift from God and what we do with our lives
is the celebration of this gift.

As we give our resources to fund the work of First Church,
may we rejoice in the beauty that we are as a gathered community
that comes from near and far.

Together may we give thanks for all that is good in the world.
For that mystery we name God...
For the sage we name Jesus...
For the renewing strength and freedom of the Spirit...

This morning we join our celebration to all people
with the gifts of our hearts - and our lives.

Offertory

Rondo

John Carter

Brandon Harris, *Soloist*, Dr. Emma Whitten, *Piano*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Megan to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

MM

For all that has been and for all that will be,
we give you our thanks, O God.

May these gifts be used to nurture the life
around us and among us,

as our lives grow
by the generosity of our hands,
and our hearts.

May it ever be so.
Amen and amen.

Please be seated

[Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML

Words of Blessing

Mysteries, Yes

ML

Truly, we live with mysteries too marvelous
to be understood.

How grass can be nourishing in the
mouths of lambs.
How rivers and stones are forever
in allegiance with gravity
while we ourselves dream of rising.
How two hands touch and the bonds
will never be broken.
How people come, from delight or the
scars of damage,
to the comfort of a poem.

Let me keep my distance, always, from those
who think they have the answers.

Let me keep company always with those who say
'Look!' and laugh in astonishment,
and bow their heads.

-Mary Oliver

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

Every Time I Feel the Spirit
Scott Graff, *Soloist*

Traditional Spiritual
arr. William Dawson

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn for the Journey**

How Deep the Silence of the Soul

KINGSFOLD

How Deep the Silence of the Soul_KINGSFOLD_2021-7-18)

- [PDF](#)
- [LYRICS \(OW\)](#)

How deep the silence of the soul that lives within your grace.
How full the gratitude of heart in your abiding place.
What rich serenity is found, what courage and release
when Wisdom teaches us to seek the gentle path to peace.

Like unseen chimes on moving air, like warm and morning sun,
Like glad-denying, green-ing, grow-ing things, like trees with blooms begun.
Such is your presence in our lives, you touch without a trace,
until we turn and find ourselves held fast in your embrace.

-Lyrics by Sylvia Dunstan

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Lucis creator – Dorothy Papadakos (b. 1960)

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music Dr. Ianthe Marini

The sacred potential of a moment. I could think of no better summoning for the day than the call to action offered to us by the late Congressman John Lewis, stalwart champion of the civil rights movement. “*Get into good trouble. Necessary trouble*”—was his imperative rallying cry. The encouragement for moral courage, persistence, and perseverance for each of us to do our part in insisting on the dignity of all. In the choral introit, we recognize that THIS day has *challenged us to make good trouble...to make this world a better place*. The sacred potential of a moment, indeed.

We then move to Mari Esabel Valverde’s musical meditation on Rilke’s evocative poem, *I Flow: I Am*. In moments of challenge and discord—I am. In moments of personal suffering and community despair—I am. “*And if the world has ceased to hear you, say to the silent earth: I flow. To the rushing water speak: I am.*” Echoing Elijah’s experience of God in the silence: when stirred to this sacred moment—we are. We then celebrate the arrival of the Jesus who seized the moment and came to heal the nations as Brandon and Dr. Whitten offer John Carter’s rousing rondo. *Peter-ring-them-bells!* Ring out this moment of justice–freedom–equity. And in choral response to this spirit, every time we feel it moving in our souls, for its sacred potential in any given moment: we pray.